

Outlier vs the Big Four: AI transformation for a 50 to 100 person

Deloitte, PwC, EY and KPMG are remarkable organisations. They combine audit, tax, legal and consulting under one roof, and each of them has invested heavily in artificial intelligence. If you run a boutique advisory, mobility, HR, legal or recruitment firm, you have probably worked with one of them. Maybe one of them audits you.

So why would a firm of 60 people choose The Outlier for its AI work instead?

This article is our honest answer. It is not a takedown. The Big Four are very good at what they are built for. They are just built for something else. Think of the old Mac and PC adverts. The PC was not a bad machine. It was a capable, serious machine designed for the enterprise. The Mac was designed for a different kind of user. That is the difference we want to explain.

t the Big Four do

Start with the facts, because they are impressive.

Deloitte reported aggregate global revenue of US\$70.5 billion for its 2025 fiscal year, with a workforce of more than 470,000 people across more than 150 countries and territories. The same announcement states that Deloitte has allocated over US\$3 billion of investment in generative AI through fiscal year 2030 (Deloitte, FY2025 revenue announcement).

PwC US announced in April 2023 that it would invest US\$1 billion over three years to expand its AI capabilities, in a relationship with Microsoft built on Azure OpenAI Service (PwC US press release).

EY launched its EY.ai platform in September 2023, following US\$1.4 billion of investment, and released its own large language model, EY.ai EYQ (EY newsroom).

KPMG committed US\$2 billion to Microsoft cloud and AI services over five years in an expanded alliance announced in July 2023, with plans to train its global workforce on the new tools (CFO Dive).

These are serious commitments. The Big Four bring deep regulatory knowledge, global networks, audit-grade risk frameworks and benches of specialists in almost every field. When a multinational bank needs to roll out AI across forty countries under the eye of several regulators, that bench matters.

Our founder knows this world from the inside. Fariza Sbaa spent nearly two decades in HR, Global Mobility, Governance, Compliance and Transformation at ING Bank, Heineken International and Media.Monks. She has worked alongside large advisory firms on large programmes. She respects what they do.

re a boutique firm sits in that pic

Here is the structural reality. A firm with hundreds of thousands of people needs large engagements to keep that machine running. That is not a criticism. It is arithmetic.

The classic consulting model is often described as a pyramid: a small number of senior partners who sell and steer the work, supported by larger teams of junior staff who do much of the analysis. Harvard Business Review described this model in 2025 and noted that AI is pushing firms toward smaller, more senior-heavy teams (HBR, "AI Is Changing the Structure of Consulting Firms"). The shift is real, but it takes time inside an organisation of that size.

For a 70-person partnership, this tends to show up in a few ways. These are general industry patterns and our opinion, not claims about any specific engagement:

There is one more point worth knowing. If a Big Four firm audits your company, independence rules can limit what advisory work the same network may take on. For public-interest entities in the EU, those limits are written into law (Regulation (EU) No 537/2014, Article 5). Most firms of your size are not public-interest entities, but it is a fair question to ask before you start.

The Outlier works ins

The Outlier was built for one kind of client: boutique firms of 50 to 100 people whose value lives in the heads of their experts. We do not try to be a smaller version of a big firm. We work differently on purpose.

senior person does the

When you hire The Outlier, the person who interviews your partners is the person who maps your processes and builds your roadmap. There is no hand-off to a team you have never met. The corporate experience you are buying is in the room, every week.

weeks, not two quar

Our AI Friction Scan takes two weeks. We interview three to five partners and five to eight people on the floor, map your three heaviest workflows, and give you one roadmap with payback figures per item. Not a forty-page report. A list you can pick up on Monday.

ed prices, published upf

You know what you pay before we start:

No day-rate surprises. No change requests that double the budget.

It in the tools you already

We build inside Microsoft 365, Google Workspace and your existing CRM. We do not ask you to adopt a new platform so that we can sell you a licence. When we leave, your team owns the system, the documentation and a maintenance plan.

erts stay at the ce

Your firm sells judgement. AI should take the repetitive work off your experts' desks, not replace them. Every system we build is designed with the people who will use it, and we measure it before and after in hours and euros.

e by

| | The Big Four | The Outlier |

|---|---|---|

| Built for | Global enterprises and listed companies | Boutique firms of 50 to 100 people |

| Who does the work | Leveraged teams, partner oversight | The senior founder, hands on |

| Time to first insight | Varies by scope and approvals | Two-week AI Friction Scan |

| Pricing | Scoped per engagement | Fixed, published prices |

| Technology | Proprietary platforms and alliances | Your existing tools (M365, Google, CRM) |

| Breadth | Audit, tax, legal, risk, tech, strategy | AI and transformation, nothing else |

| Global reach | 150+ countries | NL and BE, expanding to Europe and the UAE |

n a Big Four firm is the right ch

We would rather tell you this now than waste your time.

Choose a Big Four firm if you need AI work tightly bound to a statutory audit, a tax restructuring or a regulatory investigation. Choose one if you operate in many jurisdictions at once and need a single provider with local teams in each. Choose one if your board requires a household name on the report for governance reasons. And choose one if your programme is so large that it genuinely needs fifty people on it.

Those are real needs. The Big Four meet them well.

n The Outlier is the better

Choose The Outlier if you are a partnership of 50 to 100 people and you recognise this picture:

You do not need a global programme. You need one senior person who understands how a partnership works, who can find the friction in two weeks and build the first system in one quarter.

The PC is a fine machine. We are the Mac.

re to s

If you want to know where your firm stands, take the free assessment at /start. It takes a few minutes and tells you whether a scan makes sense. If it does, the AI Friction Scan gives you a clear roadmap in two weeks, for a fixed €2,750. If it does not, we will say so.

Company names are trademarks of their respective owners. This comparison reflects publicly available information as of October 2026.